Almost immediately upon his return to Agra, Akbar abolished the jiziya tax. The jiziya had been an overt symbol of inferiority for the Hindus, establishing through law that the Muslims were the favoured ruling class and the Hindus the dhimmis, tolerated and protected by the Muslim rulers. While previous Muslim rulers had used a great deal of discretion when adhering to the sharia, the jiziya had remained. The jiziya, according to historian John F. Richards, also ‘placed a real burden on the poorest taxpayers who paid an annual sum equivalent to a month’s wages for an unskilled urban laborer’. Akbar had to face the vehement opposition of the ulema, ‘the disapproval of statesmen’ and ‘much chatter on the part of the ignorant’. The abolition of the jiziya was done when Akbar was only twenty-one years old, ten years before he ever met Abu’l Fazl, who is sometimes credited with complete influence over Akbar in his humanitarian transformation. At this point in time, in fact, Akbar may have been seeing these discriminatory practices through the eyes of his young Rajput bride and his Kachhwaha noblemen.

The darbar that Akbar held at this time, between his war camps and Agra, was informal and filled with bonhomie, as the young Padshah met with his trusted men and discussed the state of affairs with his wakil and diwan and dispensed justice, directed departments of state and inspected the army. The Padshah’s entrance into the darbar was announced by the beating of a drum, and all the noblemen assembled performed the kornish, raising the palm of the right hand to the forehead, and bending the head. This early court was vastly different from the hushed darbars of some of Akbar’s heirs, in which the muted rustle of a courtier’s garment was loud as a gunshot.

All the mansabdars and amirs were expected to attend on the Padshah regularly, and failure to do so was considered a very grave dereliction of duty. All officers served at the court for a month, mounting guard duty once a week. At the darbar, the men professed their undying loyalty to Akbar in a complicated ritual of symbolism and the Padshah was able to look at his amirs closely and judge the truth that lay in their hearts. Despite his warm approachability and genially relaxed manner, Akbar was strict with those who presumed on his youth and inexperience, his flaring nostrils and flashing eyes sure signs of his sudden, explosive temper, which his courtiers quickly learned to read. Failure to maintain decorum in court could lead to harsh punishments. Shah Abu’l Maa’li, a personal friend of Humayun’s, was imprisoned for the temerity of not dismounting when greeting the